



Q How can I identify common illnesses and complaints?

Often it's clear when your baby is not well—he may be irritable, not feeding as usual, and lethargic. A fever is a clear sign that he is fighting infection (see p.291), and a stuffed nose and cough are easy to spot, as are stomach upsets. Other signs are less obvious: perhaps your baby is clingier than usual or isn't feeding well. Trust your instincts: if you think something isn't quite right, call your doctor.



Dehydration

» Symptoms:

Fewer wet diapers than usual, dark yellow urine, hard stools, and constipation are all signs of dehydration. Other signs include lethargy, crying without producing tears; a dry, sticky mouth; and/or a sunken fontanelle (the soft spot on his head).

» What you should do:

If your baby is suffering with vomiting, diarrhea, or has a temperature (see p.292), try to keep his fluid intake up to prevent dehydration from occurring in the first place. Offer frequent breast or formula feeding (you may need to give small feedings more often). If your baby has any of the above symptoms of dehydration, contact your doctor. He may suggest oral rehydration solution (available from pharmacies) between feeds; cooled, boiled water may be given instead if your baby refuses the solution.



Frequent breast-feeding Feeding your baby often ensures that his fluid levels are maintained.



Cradle cap

» Symptoms:

Scaly patches on the scalp that may be thick and crusty. These may be caused by overactive sebaceous glands in the first months, which then settle down. Cradle cap is usually harmless and doesn't cause itchiness or discomfort.

» What you should do:

Cradle cap typically clears up within weeks or months, and can usually be managed at home. For mild cradle cap, wash your baby's hair regularly with a baby shampoo to prevent scales from building up, and use a baby brush to loosen flakes. Massaging a little olive oil into the head and leaving this overnight softens the scales before brushing in the morning. Don't pick the scales since this could damage skin and cause an infection. If cradle cap is persistent, ask your pharmacist about stronger shampoos to loosen cradle cap. If patches spread to the face or body, self-help measures don't work, or there's bleeding or inflammation, consult your doctor.



Eczema

» Symptoms:

Red, dry, and itchy skin on the face, and in areas where the skin creases, such as the elbows, knees, and in the neck. The condition often starts in babies between two and four months old and may be connected to an allergy to milk.

» What you should do:

Talk to your doctor about managing your baby's eczema. He or she can advise you on treatments such as emollient moisturizing creams, and may prescribe a topical corticosteroid. Scratch mittens can stop your baby from damaging his skin further, and keep your baby's nails short. Avoid bath products if your baby has a flare-up, and use nonbiological laundry detergent for your baby's clothes. If the eczema is stubborn and sore, talk to your doctor about other remedies, such as wet wraps, which can help the skin to heal.



Thrush

» Symptoms:

If your baby has oral thrush, a condition caused by the yeast fungus *Candida albicans*, he may have a white coating on his tongue and white patches around the mouth with a curdlike texture. These don't rub off easily and, if sore, can interfere with feeding. Your baby may also have a diaper rash caused by the same infection. If you are breast-feeding, the infection can be passed between you and your baby and can make your nipples sore and painful.

» What you should do:

Make an appointment with your doctor. While the condition isn't usually serious, he or she may prescribe an antifungal medicine or gel for your baby. If you're breast-feeding, your doctor may prescribe an antifungal cream for your nipples.



Conjunctivitis

» Symptoms:

This eye infection causes an inflammation of the thin membrane (conjunctiva) covering the white of the eye. The eye is red, inflamed, itchy, sticky, and watery, and there may be a discharge. The eye may be crusted over after sleep. It is caused either by an infection, or an allergy or irritant, such as cigarette smoke. In newborns, conjunctivitis may be contracted from bacteria in the birth canal.

» What you should do:

Use cotton pads soaked in cooled boiled water to remove the crust and goo from your baby's eye, using a separate cotton pad for each eye so you don't pass infection between them. Wash your hands after touching your baby and use a separate towel to stop the infection from spreading to others. If your baby is under 28 days old, or the infection is severe or doesn't clear up after a week or so, contact your doctor because your baby may have a bacterial infection that needs treatment with eye drops.